

Death of God and Freedom

At first glance, the layout of *The Gay Science* seems akin to neutral chaos. There is no underlying theme or a point of consistency that the reader can trace as Nietzsche jumps from idea to idea. Nonetheless, amidst the whirlwind, he exhibits a kind of artistic ambiance. It is balanced, not overly serious nor playful to the extent of hedonism. For example, the first aphorism, *New battles*, is not a channel for the spiteful nihilist to vex the faithful. His practical concern is what happens following the death of Buddha and God, not the blasphemy of the act itself. In an ode to Plato's cave allegory, the shadows of the divine remain on the walls long after their passing. As figures of the darkness, they are no longer the benevolent deities they were meant to memorialize, but people view them in awe all the same. In the search for freedom, Nietzsche suggests that the end of authority is not enough; an empty vessel simply cannot be filled with liberty. Defeating the shadow is a much more brutal process. Continuing, the experimental nature of Nietzsche's ethics is confirmed in *The madman*. In this hypothetical, society has managed to move forward. However, in doing so, they no longer have a purpose which was previously bestowed by God. The marketplace is a setting of monotonous consumption without meaning. Nietzsche, embodying the madman alienated by truth, cautions his readers on becoming jaded with the forgetting of God, and ultimately losing their freedom again. Without the context of the larger work, it is easy to assume contradiction on Nietzsche's part. The nail on the coffin is *What does your conscience say?* In distinguishing two forms of the present you, Nietzsche suggests that conscience is separate and thinking as a form of dialogue. This would ultimately explain the speculative manner in which he explicates the death of god. Its un-absoluteness provides practicality. The only thing we do know is there are better ways of living.